

CONTRACT CHECKLIST GUIDE

What every player should confirm before signing a professional basketball contract.

A practical field guide by Elijah Bryant.
Read every word. Ask every question. Keep the final say.

START HERE

A PROMISE IS NOT A CONTRACT.

The headline salary is only one part of the deal. Your contract should clearly explain what you earn, what the team provides, what happens if you are injured or released, and how disagreements are handled.

IF IT MATTERS TO YOU, GET IT IN WRITING.

- ☐ Read the entire contract yourself. Do not rely only on a summary from your agent.
- ☐ Compare the final contract against the offer you accepted in messages or email.
- ☐ Ask questions until you understand every clause. Confusion is a reason to pause.
- ☐ Have an independent lawyer review the agreement when possible.
- ☐ Have a qualified tax professional explain your obligations in every relevant country.

WRITE IT DOWN

KNOW THE WHOLE DEAL.

TEAM / COUNTRY _____	LEAGUE / COMPETITION _____
CONTRACT START DATE _____	CONTRACT END DATE _____
BASE SALARY _____	NET OR GROSS? _____
CURRENCY _____	NUMBER OF PAYMENTS _____
MONTHLY PAYMENT DATE _____	GUARANTEED AMOUNT _____
BONUSES _____	AGENT FEE / WHO PAYS? _____
HOUSING _____	CAR / TRANSPORTATION _____
FLIGHTS _____	INSURANCE _____

DO NOT COMPARE CONTRACTS UNTIL YOU COMPARE WHAT YOU ACTUALLY TAKE HOME.

SECTION 01

FOLLOW EVERY DOLLAR.

1 SALARY LANGUAGE

- ☐ Is the salary explicitly written as **net** or **gross**?
- ☐ What exact amount should reach your account after local deductions?
- ☐ Which currency will you be paid in, and who carries exchange-rate risk?
- ☐ Are bonuses objective, measurable, and tied to clear payment dates?

NET SALARY

The contract states what reaches you after agreed local taxes and deductions. Confirm the definition and exceptions.

GROSS SALARY

Taxes and other deductions come out of the stated amount. Your actual take-home can be much lower.

2 TAXES + FEES

- ☐ Who files and pays local taxes? Will you receive official proof of payment?
- ☐ Could wealth, residency, social-security, or other local taxes apply?
- ☐ What may still be owed in your home country? Americans should ask about foreign tax credits and filing obligations.
- ☐ Who pays the agent fee? Do not assume the custom is identical in every league.
- ☐ Are ELPA, union, licensing, federation, or registration fees deducted?

Spain, Turkey, Dubai, and every other market can treat compensation differently. Never use one country's tax experience to estimate another deal.

SECTION 02

KNOW WHEN YOU GET PAID.

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SCHEDULE + METHOD

- ☐ Are every payment amount and due date written into the contract?
- ☐ When is the first payment? Is any signing bonus due before travel?
- ☐ Who pays bank fees, transfer charges, and currency-conversion costs?
- ☐ What documentation proves a payment was sent and received?

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LATE OR MISSING MONEY

- ☐ How many days late can a payment be before the team is in breach?
- ☐ Is there written notice and a cure period before you can take action?
- ☐ Can you stop playing or terminate if nonpayment continues?
- ☐ Are penalties or interest owed on late payments?
- ☐ Where are disputes filed: BAT, federation arbitration, league process, or local court?

A PAYMENT DATE WITHOUT A REMEDY IS NOT ENOUGH PROTECTION.

SECTION 03

PUT THE LIFESTYLE IN WRITING.

5 HOUSING + TRANSPORTATION

-
- ☐ Is housing furnished, private, safe, and available when you arrive?
-
- ☐ Who pays rent, utilities, internet, deposits, repairs, and cleaning?
-
- ☐ Is a car provided? Who pays fuel, insurance, maintenance, tolls, and tickets?
-
- ☐ If there is no car, what transportation is guaranteed?

6 FLIGHTS + FAMILY

-
- ☐ How many flights are included, for whom, and at what baggage allowance?
-
- ☐ Are preseason arrival, holiday, emergency, and end-of-season flights covered?
-
- ☐ Who handles and pays for visas, permits, translations, and renewals?
-
- ☐ Are spouse and child visas, insurance, school, or childcare addressed?
-
- ☐ Are hotel arrangements and single rooms on road trips clear?

Families will buy toys, kitchen appliances, and everyday items they may later give away. You are living, not camping. Budget for a real life, then clarify what the team provides.

SECTION 04

PROTECT YOUR BODY.

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MEDICAL COVERAGE

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- ☐ Does insurance cover practice, games, travel, rehabilitation, surgery, and off-court emergencies?
-
- ☐ When does coverage begin and end?
-
- ☐ Who chooses the doctor, and do you have a written right to an independent second opinion?
-
- ☐ Will you receive copies of imaging, bloodwork, diagnoses, and treatment records?
-
- ☐ Who pays for treatment if care continues after release or after the season?

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INJURY + SALARY

-
- ☐ Is salary guaranteed if you are injured during team activity?
-
- ☐ Can the team reduce salary, suspend you, or terminate for injury?
-
- ☐ What happens if the preseason physical identifies a prior condition?
-
- ☐ Is there a clear return-to-play process and who makes the final decision?

THE TEAM DOCTOR WORKS FOR THE TEAM. KEEP YOUR OWN RECORDS.

SECTION 05

KNOW HOW THE DEAL ENDS.

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RELEASE + TERMINATION

☐ Is there a tryout or cut window where the team can release you and owe little or nothing?

☐ What counts as "cause," and is there a warning or cure period?

☐ If released without cause, what salary remains guaranteed and when is it due?

☐ Can the team replace you but delay your release paperwork or transfer clearance?

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BUYOUT + OPTIONS

☐ What does it cost you or a new team to leave early?

☐ Who holds each option, what is the deadline, and how must notice be delivered?

☐ Does an NBA, EuroLeague, or higher-league out clause exist?

☐ Can you terminate for nonpayment, unsafe conditions, visa failure, or material breach?

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DISPUTES

☐ Which law governs the contract, and what is the official contract language?

☐ Where will a dispute be heard, who pays costs, and can the decision be enforced?

PAUSE BEFORE SIGNING

PRESSURE IS INFORMATION.

"THAT IS STANDARD."

Standard does not mean good for you. Ask where it is written and what it means.

"WE WILL FIX IT LATER."

If the promise matters, change the contract before signing.

MISSING TRANSLATION

Never sign a version you cannot fully read and compare.

BLANK SPACES

No missing numbers, dates, exhibits, schedules, or attachments.

DIFFERENT COPIES

Every signed language version should match on the terms that matter.

UNCLEAR GUARANTEES

"Guaranteed" should state the amount, conditions, and payment timing.

ONE-SIDED EXIT

Pay attention when the team has many ways out and you have none.

NO OUTSIDE REVIEW

Anyone discouraging independent advice deserves extra scrutiny.

YOUR AGENT ADVISES YOU. YOU MAKE THE DECISION.

An agent may be balancing several clients, team relationships, or referral arrangements. That does not automatically make the recommendation wrong, but it means you should verify the situation independently and understand every incentive around the deal.

SCREENSHOT THIS

BEFORE YOU SIGN ANYTHING.

☐ Net or gross salary confirmed☐ Currency and exchange risk confirmed☐ Payment dates confirmed☐ Guaranteed salary confirmed☐ Housing and utilities confirmed☐ Flights and baggage confirmed☐ Insurance coverage confirmed☐ Second-opinion right confirmed☐ Buyout and options confirmed☐ All promises are in writing☐ Taxes and proof of payment confirmed☐ Agent fee and payer confirmed☐ Late-payment remedy confirmed☐ Bonuses written clearly☐ Car or transportation confirmed☐ Family visas and support confirmed☐ Injury protection confirmed☐ Release language confirmed☐ Dispute process confirmed☐ Final signed copy saved offline

REVIEWED WITH

DATE

UNDERSTAND THE DEAL. KEEP YOUR RECORDS. KEEP THE FINAL SAY.